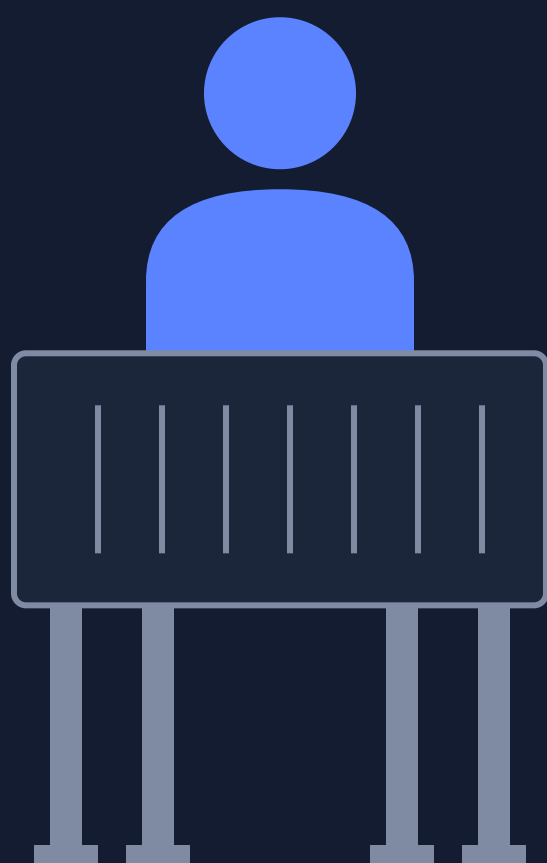


Be a centaur, *not a reverse centaur.*

PLATE I

Centaur

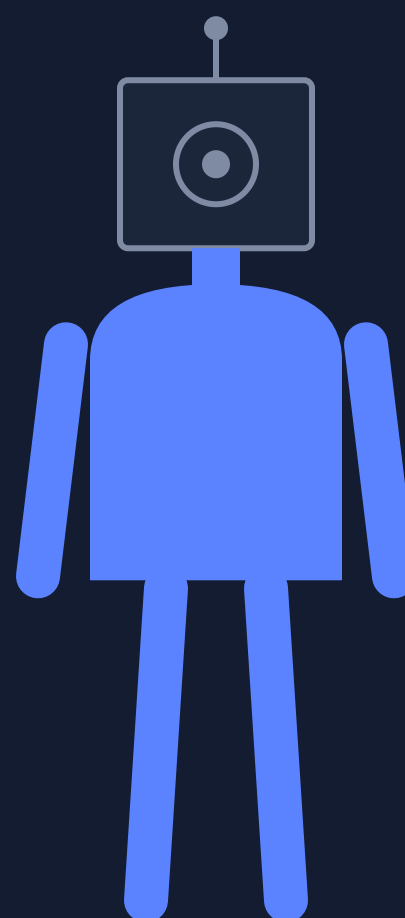


■ HEAD · YOU
choose the shape

□ BODY · THE AGENT
serves it

PLATE II

Reverse centaur



□ HEAD · THE AGENT
chooses the shape

■ BODY · YOU
process it

The agent kept choosing the shape

300+

tasks generated in the first 60 days. Due dates never set. Action items built on assumptions that weren't true.

YOU ASKED

IT RETURNED

“Help me think this through”

→ A confident recommendation

“What are the tensions here?”

→ A decision matrix

“I’m not sure what I believe yet”

→ A position, inferred for you

Raw meeting notes

→ A follow-up task for every concern

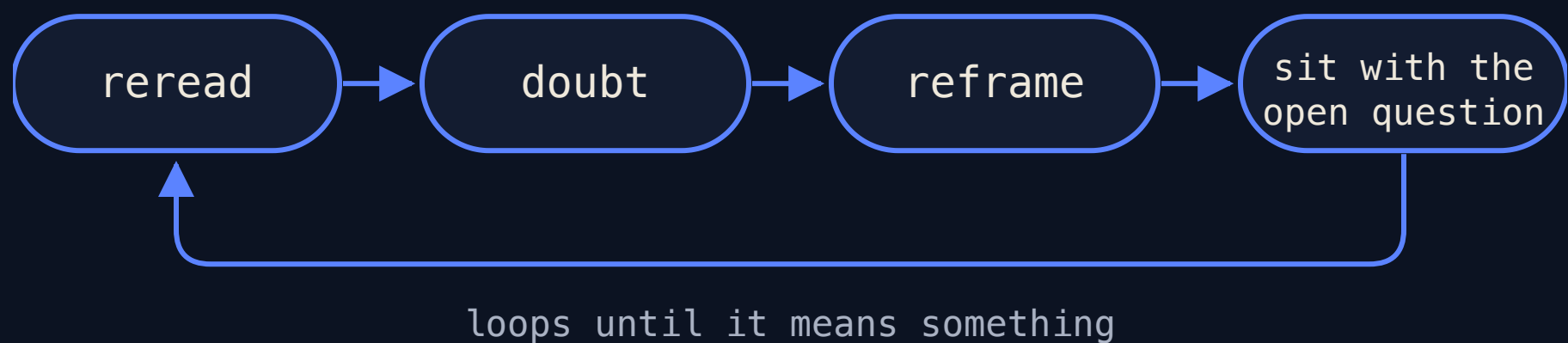
THE PATTERN, NAMED ON STAGE

Agents optimizing for *closure* when users need *cognition*.

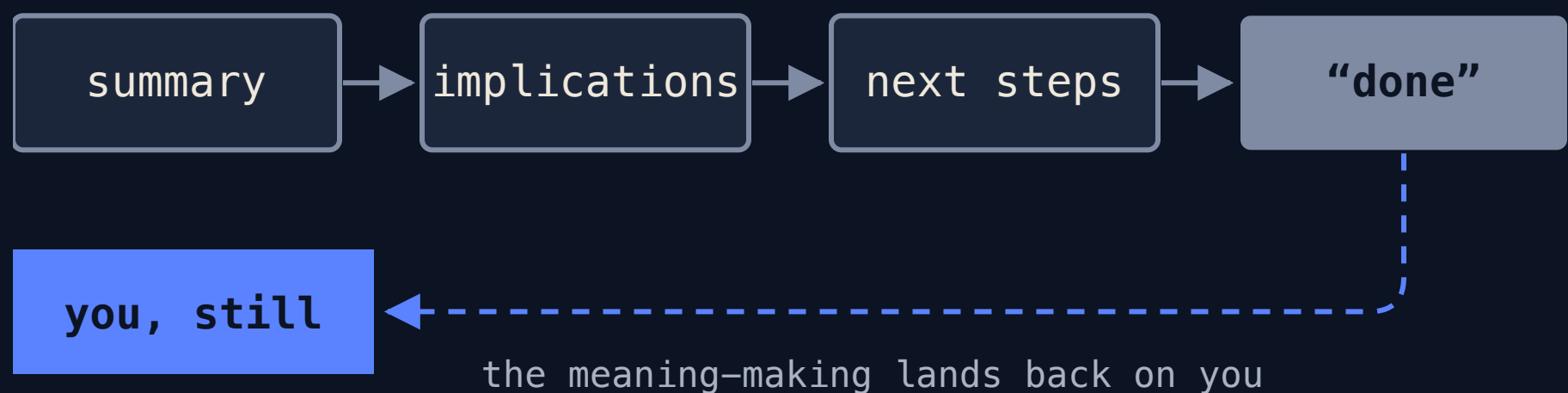
WHY IT HAPPENS

Reflection becomes throughput

THINKING ON YOUR OWN



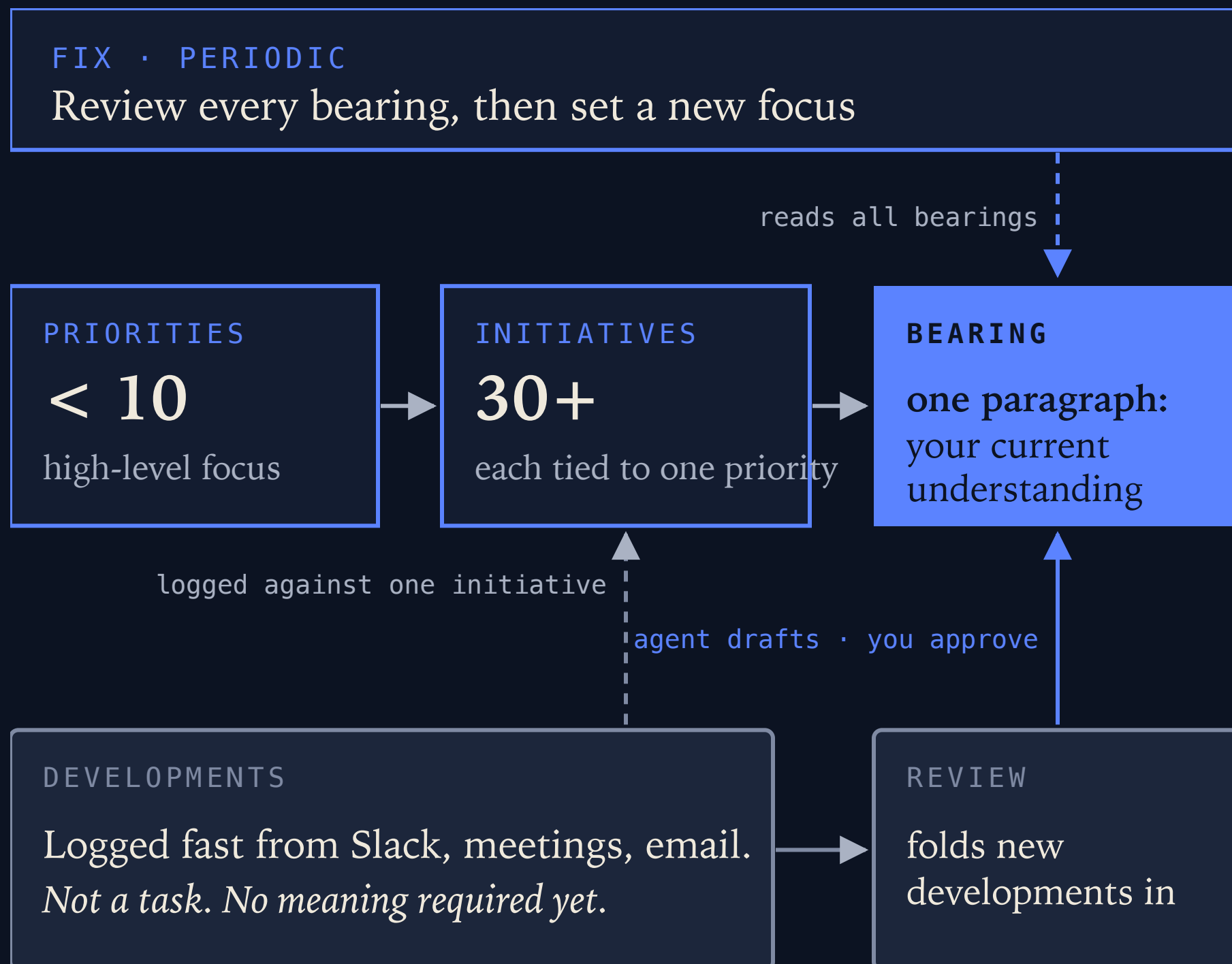
WITH A CLOSURE-SEEKING AGENT



319 knowledge workers surveyed: more confidence in GenAI went with less critical thinking, as effort shifted from solving problems to verifying output.

Source: Lee et al., Microsoft Research + Carnegie Mellon, CHI 2025 (self-reported survey, correlational) · lanes adapted from Holt's talk

Let it evolve. Keep the shape.



■ you own it □ the agent can help

Source: Bradley Holt (Datadog), personal knowledge system shown at LeadDev New York, Sept 14, 2026 · “Specific to me; may or may not work for you.”

How to stay the centaur

WHEN THINKING

Tell the agent you're in thinking mode. Don't let it push you into closing.

WHEN BUILDING

Start with little structure. Add it where things break, before the agent invents its own.

WHEN STORING

Make provenance visible: [your understanding](#) vs. the agent's.

SAME IDEA, PLANNING SIDE · PRANAY PRABHAT, NYT GAMES

Above the line: commitments

sized by the teams, risks flagged by engineering ICs

THE LINE

Below the line: stretch

pulled in only if there's room